

■■ Default Bias

■ What is it?

The tendency to accept the default option.

People usually stick with what's pre-set instead of actively changing it—unless they have a strong reason to do so.

For example, most people use the suggested settings on a new phone instead of customizing every detail.

■■ History

The term “default bias” comes from **behavioral economics and psychology research** in the 1980s–1990s.

Studies showed that people are far more likely to accept pre-set options in areas like healthcare, savings, and subscriptions. This helped popularize the concept of “**nudging**”—subtle design choices that guide behavior without forcing it.

■ The Psychology Behind It

Our brains like shortcuts. Defaults reduce effort by providing a ready-made path. Instead of weighing every choice, people often accept the option already selected.

This leads to:

- Saving mental energy
- Faster decisions
- Easy habit formation

But defaults can also lock users into poor choices if not designed well.

■■ Why It Matters

Default bias can:

- Boost conversions and adoption rates
- Drive higher sales for pre-set packages

- Build habits quickly
- But also cause frustration if defaults aren't user-friendly
- Lead to poor outcomes when ineffective options are pre-set

■ How to Apply It

- **Use smart defaults** → base them on data or common behaviors.
- **Offer easy-to-understand alternatives** → clear explanations for other choices.
- **Encourage exploration** → use CTAs to show other options.
- **Feedback mechanisms** → show benefits of customizing through comparisons or testimonials.
- **Refresh defaults** → adapt them over time to stay relevant.

■ Theory in Action

- **Online forms** often have “auto-save” enabled by default, reducing user stress.
- **Fast food chains** push combo meals as the profitable default instead of separate items.

■ Final Thought

Defaults are powerful because most people accept them. Use them wisely—set helpful, user-friendly options while keeping the door open for easy customization.